back of the legs. I couldn't help the instinctive reaction. I tumbled over, expecting the worst: angry at Martin, angry at Aldo Duscher, angry at everything. It took a second to realize that, for the first time in a couple of months, somewhere else was actually hurting worse than my foot. Pain's never given me so much pleasure. Like I say, I should have been waiting for him. Martin will always be the one to test you: he'll whack you, challenge you to be up to it, find out if you've got the nerve. He knew and I knew that, come Sunday, there'd be someone ready to do the same thing he had just done. The difference would be that if a Swedish player did it, it would be in the hope that I wouldn't get up again. Here, I scraped myself off the floor and carried on. If I could survive Martin, I could probably survive anybody. The foot was really sore even before we'd finished the session, but I was just pleased to have got through it. Working with the other lads lifted me for the rest of the week.

It was a great squad to be part of, especially once we arrived in Japan and the players started looking forward to getting on with the tournament. The atmosphere amongst the group we had out in Japan was special. What was going on outside the camp, though? I don't think any of us had ever seen anything like it. It started the moment we got off the plane in Tokyo: walking out through the terminal was unbelievable. There were thousands of Japanese waiting to meet us: mums, dads, children and teenagers, who'd made England their team for the tournament. They were wearing our shirts. It was almost like a pop concert, with fans waving, shouting, pushing forward, and the police struggling to hold them back. As we climbed onto the team bus, I caught one old lady out of the corner of my eye: well into her seventies, I'd say, with snow-white hair and a bright red stripe dyed through it. Parents were holding their children up above the bobbing heads. These kids were too young to have a clue who I was, but lots of them had copied my haircut: the blonde streak and the mohican. And had the number 7 on their shirts. It was chaotic, but in a polite way that's maybe characteristic of the Japanese. They were excited to see us, so positive about the team and about the English. I think their attitude had a lot to do with why there weren't any crowd problems during the World Cup, even though people had been worrying about trouble happening for months leading up to the tournament. Instead, it turned out the people there had the same passion for soccer that we do. Our supporters were welcomed and, credit to them, England fans made the effort in return. That spirit is what World Cups should be about.

For a player, of course, the World Cup is all about playing. Leading England out at the stadium in Saitama, for our first game of the 2002 tournament against Sweden, will always be one of the proudest moments of